

Chapter 128-1

Traffic flowed like shuttles on the road, and the sound of tires rubbing against the ground seemed particularly jarring at this moment.

The spring breeze carried fine threads of rain over, making the branches that had just sprouted green buds appear even more tender and delicate.

In an instant, this city gained warmth.

The young woman wore a white dress, her long hair slightly curled, with a very standard oval face. She had paired a denim jacket over her white dress, looking gentle yet full of vitality.

The wispy hair on her forehead was dampened by sweat and rain. Under Liang Shi's prolonged silent gaze, she reached up to touch the stray hairs on her forehead.

Her hands still had mud from having just moved flower pots, her palms fair with a rosy tint—one could tell at a glance that she was pampered and had never done much dirty or heavy work.

Being stared at by Liang Shi with such a complicated gaze, she felt a bit embarrassed, awkwardly smiling as she wiped her face.

Unable to endure this silence any longer, she said sheepishly, "Is there something on my face?"

Only then did Liang Shi come back to her senses, also realizing her rudeness just now, and immediately said, "Sorry."

"It's fine, it's fine." The young woman said, pausing for a moment. "You look a bit familiar to me."

Liang Shi was surprised. "Hm?"

"That's right!" The young woman's eyes lit up. "You played Wang Jing, right?"

Wang Jing was a role Liang Shi had played not long after her debut—a workplace newbie.

When that drama aired, everyone was saying: We're all Wang Jing, but none of us are as good as Wang Jing.

That role had also gained her quite a few fans, as well as nationwide recognition.

Liang Shi nodded, but still asked unwillingly, "Besides in the TV drama? You haven't seen me anywhere else?"

After saying this, she introduced herself, "My name is Liang Shi."

"Only on TV." The young woman smiled. "How would ordinary people like us ever cross paths with big celebrities like you?"

But a moment later, the young woman asked in surprise, "But... how did you know my name is Qi Jiao?"

Liang Shi stared at her face.

Even if they had looked sixty to seventy percent similar during puberty, a plastic surgeon couldn't possibly imagine what a person would look like as an adult based on their adolescent appearance.

So Qi Jiao's face wasn't very similar to Gu Xingyue's. Even if Yang Jiani had found a particularly skilled plastic surgeon, it would have been impossible to replicate Gu Xingyue into a second Qi Jiao.

They looked sixty to seventy percent alike during puberty, and now they were still sixty to seventy percent alike.

Not a bit more.

The reason Liang Shi had subconsciously called out Qi Jiao's name was entirely based on photos of Qi Jiao from her adolescence.

The Qi Jiao from back then hadn't changed much from now—she was almost like an enlarged version.

Her brows and eyes had fully grown in, the corners of her lips curved in a smile, gentle and beautiful.

Only she was missing the melancholic air that had been visible in the photos before.

It seemed she was living happily.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, then said in a low voice, "I have a friend who's also named Qi Jiao, and she looks a lot like you."

"Is that so..." Qi Jiao nodded to herself. "That's quite a coincidence."

The spring rain began to patter down again. In front of the flower shop, there was only an eave a few dozen centimeters wide to shelter from the rain, and Liang Shi was completely exposed to it.

Qi Jiao stood under the eave, the wind blowing her white dress.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of Chen Mian's profile picture. She pressed her lips together and asked, "Do you know Chen Mian?"

Qi Jiao shook her head, the movement somewhat slow. She knocked on her own head. "I don't know, but the name does sound familiar to me too."

Qi Jiao said that she had once had a high fever in middle school that lasted three days and three nights, and she nearly became an idiot from the fever. After that, her memory became very poor.

She would often forget trivial things in life, and couldn't really remember some people either.

"Middle school?" Liang Shi sensitively caught onto this timeframe. "When was it?"

"Third year of middle school."¹ Qi Jiao said, "My parents said it was because of too much academic pressure. After the fever, my brain became really sluggish, and I didn't have any talent for studying at all. I didn't get into my desired school, and my high school studies were also mediocre. It was just terrible."

"No." Liang Shi immediately said, "You're not terrible at all."

—You're amazing.

In third year of middle school, Qi Jiao had died in that world.

In third year of middle school, Qi Jiao suddenly developed a high fever here.

Was there some connection between these events?

"How can you say that without even knowing me?" Qi Jiao smiled gently. "I only scored a little over four hundred points on the zhongkao,² and I didn't even pass the undergraduate cutoff line for the gaokao.³ I accomplished nothing academically. If it weren't for my parents, I'd probably have starved on the streets."

"Was this shop opened with your parents' help?" Liang Shi asked.

Qi Jiao nodded. "And also my older brother and sister. They're all very accomplished. I'm like the control group.⁴ But red flowers always need green leaves to set them off."

"You're very accomplished too." Liang Shi said, "Not just anyone can open a shop."

Qi Jiao stuck her tongue out at her, the mud-stained hand patting her own forehead. "Oh no! I'm venting negativity to you again. I'm sorry, I hope I haven't ruined your good mood for the day."

Liang Shi shook her head. "You haven't. I'm very happy to meet you."

Her tone was very calm, even though she was saying the words "very happy."

Qi Jiao also detected something from this. She put her hands behind her back and smiled, "I hope so."

Liang Shi didn't want to affect her current life either, so she nodded with a smile. "I'll be going now."

"Okay." Qi Jiao said.

Liang Shi opened the black umbrella in her hand, her retreating figure looking desolate. She hadn't walked far when she heard Qi Jiao calling her from behind, "Miss Liang, wait."

Liang Shi turned around and saw Qi Jiao walking quickly toward her, pulling something out of her denim jacket pocket.

Qi Jiao said, "Hold out your hand."

Liang Shi numbly extended her hand. A few seconds later, two White Rabbit milk candies⁵ landed steadily in her palm.

Qi Jiao was still standing in the rain. Liang Shi moved her umbrella over to shelter her.

Qi Jiao smiled and shook her head. "No need, you keep it. I'm going back into the shop right away."

Liang Shi's throat felt a bit dry. "Why are you giving me these?"

"Don't be unhappy." Qi Jiao said, "Life will get better."

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1. Third year of middle school (初三, chūsān): In China's education system, middle school (junior high) consists of three years, typically ages 12-15. The third year is crucial as students prepare for the high school entrance examination. ↵
 2. Zhongkao (中考): The Senior High School Entrance Examination in China, taken at the end of middle school. It determines which high school a student can attend. A score of "a little over four hundred" is generally considered quite low. ↵
 3. Gaokao (高考): The National College Entrance Examination, China's highly competitive standardized test for university admission. Not passing the undergraduate cutoff line (本科线) means a student cannot enter a four-year university program. ↵
 4. Control group (对照组): Qi Jiao is using scientific terminology humorously, comparing herself to a "control group" in an experiment—suggesting she exists to make her accomplished siblings look even better by comparison. ↵
 5. White Rabbit milk candies (大白兔奶糖): A famous Chinese candy brand that has been around since 1959. These creamy, chewy milk-flavored candies wrapped in edible rice paper are nostalgic treats associated with childhood in China. The brand features a white rabbit logo on its packaging. ↵

Chapter 128-2

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Liang Shi bought a crucian carp. The wet market was more chaotic compared to the supermarket.

She used to come here often and knew this place like the back of her hand.

After buying the fish and side ingredients, she also called Sister Wang and Xiao Bai to come to her place for lunch.

She carried her things back again.

She still took the same route from this morning.

The newly opened flower shop was the most eye-catching store on this street. The flower shop was called "Deep Sea Sleepless,"¹ carrying an artistic air.

On her way back, Liang Shi passed by the flower shop and subconsciously glanced inside.

She didn't see Qi Jiao again.

The flowers at the shop's entrance were arranged with unique creativity, and a wooden sign reading "Welcome" hung at the door.

Not seeing Qi Jiao again, Liang Shi felt somewhat disappointed.

When she returned to the entrance of her residential complex carrying her groceries, a man wearing a baseball cap and a black hoodie brushed past her.

He had a cold and aloof aura and was quite good-looking, so Liang Shi took an extra look.

Then she noticed he walked into that flower shop.

Liang Shi went home full of curiosity.

Her curiosity would go unanswered. In the past, she had Xu Qingzhu to help her work through the logic. A top student's brain was always useful—she could easily sort out clues without Liang Shi having to think much at all.

But now she could only think by herself.

Qi Jiao would hand her White Rabbit milk candies just like when she was little. She would tell her that life would definitely get better. When she smiled, her eyes would sparkle like they were mixed with crushed diamonds, and even the curve of her eyes when she smiled was the same as when she was little.

It was hard to say she wasn't the Qi Jiao from another world.

But how did she get here?

Based on her previous experience, did dying cause one to switch back and forth between the two worlds?

Then if she went and died now, could she go back?

This was an unknown.

There weren't enough reference points to prove the success rate and rationality of this matter.

Liang Shi thought while preparing the fish.

Meanwhile, in the flower shop outside the residential complex, Qi Jiao was trimming flower stems. The man wearing the baseball cap with the cold and aloof aura pushed open the door and came in. Qi Jiao stood up to greet him: "Welcome..."

Before she could finish speaking, she saw who it was and swallowed the rest of her words.

Qi Jiao broke into an even brighter smile. "Gē!² You're back."

"Mm." Qi Jun took off his baseball cap, hooking up a roguish smile. "If I hadn't heard it from Mom, I wouldn't have known you'd made something of yourself."

Qi Jiao: "..."

She pouted. "Well, I need to have something to do."

Qi Jun shrugged. "You could go to your sister's company. There's always a suitable position. Who knew you wanted to be a boss so badly."

"I'm so stupid. If I went, people would say I got in through the back door."³ Qi Jiao sat back down in her original spot and continued trimming flower stems. "I'd rather not cause trouble for you all. Opening a flower shop is so nice. Seeing people's happy expressions when they hold flowers makes me happy."

"As long as you're happy." Qi Jun smiled indulgently. "When the time comes, I'll have them all come buy flowers."

"No, no." Qi Jiao said, "Just let my shop remain a hidden gem in the city."⁴ Your fans and buddies have too much purchasing power. If they buy out my flower shop, I'll be exhausted to death."

Qi Jun was stunned for a moment. "That's true."

Afterward, Qi Jun asked if she had eaten breakfast.

Qi Jiao nodded. "I already ate. Did you forget? I need to take medicine in the morning."

"How much longer do you need to take that medicine?" Qi Jun asked. "Does it work?"

"I don't know either. They say it can improve memory, but I had my sister look at it before, and she said it's targeted at middle-aged and elderly people. But since Mom already bought it, I'll just take it." Qi Jiao smiled. "My fish-like brain probably can't be fixed anyway."

"Then stop taking it." Qi Jun said, "Mom always buys you these strange things, and you're the only one who listens to her and does everything she says."

Qi Jiao shrugged indifferently. "Well, I'm so stupid, and Mom is just looking out for me."

Qi Jun sighed helplessly. "You're too obedient."

"Everyone should have at least one good quality." Qi Jiao arranged the trimmed flower stems together, the colors beautifully coordinated. "My only remaining good quality is probably being obedient."

Qi Jun: "..."

While wrapping flowers, Qi Jiao said, "Gē, do you know Chen Mian?"

Qi Jun's hand paused while playing with his phone. He looked up and frowned. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing, I just met someone today." Qi Jiao said, "She mentioned this name, and I felt it sounded very familiar, but I still can't remember."

Including the flower shop's name "Deep Sea Sleepless"—that was also something she had thought of in a flash of inspiration.

At that time, she didn't know why, but she suddenly thought of this very artistic name.

Qi Jun thought for a moment. "I don't know. Never heard of it."

"It sounds like a very artistic name." Qi Jiao's hands were very skilled; she could easily wrap a beautiful bouquet. "I always feel like I've seen this person before, but I can't remember. This goldfish brain of mine."

"Then just don't remember." Qi Jun said, "You just need to remember us, and that's enough."

Qi Jiao nodded. "That's true."

But she always felt that Chen Mian was a very important person.

1. Deep Sea Sleepless (深海未眠, Shēnhǎi Wèimián): The shop name contains "眠" (mián), which means "sleep" and is also part of Chen Mian's name (陳眠). This is a subconscious connection Qi Jiao made without realizing it. ⇐
2. Gē (哥): A Chinese term meaning "older brother." It's commonly used as an affectionate address for an older male sibling or close male friend who is older. ⇐
3. Got in through the back door (走後門): A Chinese idiom meaning to use personal connections or nepotism to gain advantages, bypassing proper procedures or merit-based selection. ⇐
4. Hidden gem in the city (大隱隱於市): A Chinese idiom meaning "a great hermit hides in the city." It refers to someone or something that remains unassuming and hidden despite being in a bustling urban environment, choosing obscurity over fame. ⇐

Chapter 128-3

After a while, Qi Jiao spoke again: "Is Chen Mian a painter?"

Qi Jun frowned. "How would I know? Want to search it up?"

"I already searched." Qi Jiao said, "Nothing came up. There was one result about some city's 'Three Good Student.'"¹

Qi Jun fell silent.

Qi Jiao placed the wrapped bouquet on the counter. Flowers of all colors vied for attention in splendid display, and the shop was filled with rich floral fragrance.

"Then why do you say she's a painter?" Qi Jun asked.

Qi Jiao pondered for a few seconds, then smiled. "Pure intuition."

Qi Jun didn't say anything more.

He had actually heard the name Chen Mian before.

When Qi Jiao had her high fever, she kept calling out: "Chen Mian... Chen Mian..."

Qi Jun had specifically gone to her school to investigate, but couldn't find this person.

At the time, their whole family was frightened, thinking Qi Jiao was in a secret relationship. But it turned out this person didn't exist at all.

When Qi Jiao woke up and recovered, they had also asked who Chen Mian was.

But Qi Jiao had looked bewildered and said, "This name sounds so familiar? But I don't think I know them."

Qi Jun couldn't be bothered to bring up this old matter again.

Qi Jiao sat among the fresh flowers, more gentle and beautiful than the flowers themselves.

That she could grow up safely was already enough.

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Wang Zhaozhao brought a bouquet of tulips when she came.

Liang Shi was busy in the kitchen wearing an apron, inviting them to sit down and eat.

Xiao Bai ran into the kitchen like an orangutan that had just escaped from the zoo, howling: "Wuwuwu, being able to see Sister Liang cook in my lifetime is simply like a Bodhisattva descending to save all living beings! Us mortals can only go 'awoo awoo'~"²

As she spoke, she leaned close to the counter emanating rich aromas. Liang Shi pushed her away. "Go away."

"Keep making a fuss." Wang Zhaozhao stood at the kitchen doorway with her arms crossed. "Bai Qi, were you a starving ghost reincarnated?"²

Being called by her full name, Xiao Bai shrank her neck sheepishly as if the nape of her fate had been pinched. "I was just purely craving... just a little bit."

"Can't I feed you enough at home every day?" Wang Zhaozhao said, "Is it necessary?"

"How can that be the same?!" Xiao Bai rarely stood her ground. "Food from home just isn't as good as food from outside."

"Fine then, don't eat the food at home anymore." Wang Zhaozhao scoffed lightly. "You're so spoiled."

Xiao Bai instantly caved. "Jiějie, I was wrong."

Liang Shi stood in front of the counter, steam from the pot drifting around her. If you looked carefully, you could see she was holding back laughter.

Wang Zhaozhao had been in the entertainment industry for so many years and was as sharp as they come. One glance and she knew what Liang Shi was doing.

She raised an eyebrow lightly. "Little one, what are you thinking about?"

Sister Wang wasn't actually that old—thirty-four years old, twelve years older than Xiao Bai and nine years older than Liang Shi.

But she had entered this industry early; she already had half a foot in the door while still in school.

Her seniority wasn't considered high, but her methods were ruthless enough—whether toward herself or others.

People in the industry often said that Wang Zhaozhao was like a venomous snake. If anyone got bitten by her, it would definitely be fatal.

In front of her, Liang Shi and Xiao Bai were completely outclassed.

So Sister Wang often called the two of them "little ones."

Though she only called them that during casual moments when they were teasing each other.

However, during the days when Liang Shi was in a coma, this term of address had become exclusive to Xiao Bai.

So at this moment, Xiao Bai immediately responded: "Huh? I'm thinking about how to kneel down and apologize."

"Go away." Sister Wang leaned against the doorframe, her voice light and airy. "I'm talking about the other one. What inappropriate thoughts are you having?"

Being called out, Liang Shi pinched her earlobe and said quietly, "You two just sounded like you were flirting."⁴

Having already gained some experience, Liang Shi naturally couldn't help but let her mind wander when hearing such dialogue.

Xiao Bai froze for two seconds, then suddenly her cheeks turned bright red. "Sister Liang, you've changed!"

Liang Shi smiled awkwardly. "Have I...?"

"You have changed." Wang Zhaozhao stood there and said, "You're already interpreting people's normal conversation as flirting."

Liang Shi retorted: "...It's because you two were driving too fast."

"It's because you're thinking too much." Xiao Bai clicked her tongue. "I'm straight!"

Wang Zhaozhao scoffed lightly. "Who isn't?"

Liang Shi: "..."

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1. Three Good Student (三好學生, Sān Hǎo Xuéshēng): An honorary title given to outstanding students in China who excel in three areas: moral character, academic performance, and physical fitness. It's a common school award. ↵
 2. Bodhisattva descending to save all living beings (菩薩下凡普度眾生): A Buddhist expression referring to enlightened beings who compassionately come down to the mortal world to help suffering people. Xiao Bai is humorously exaggerating that Liang Shi cooking is as miraculous as divine intervention. ↵
 3. Starving ghost reincarnated (餓死鬼投胎): A common Chinese expression used to tease someone who eats ravenously or is extremely eager for food. In Chinese folk beliefs, starving ghosts are spirits who died of hunger and are eternally famished. ↵
 4. Flirting / "driving" (開車): Chinese internet slang where "driving" (開車) refers to making suggestive or flirtatious remarks. The phrase "driving too fast" (車速太快) means the conversation became too suggestive too quickly. ↵

Chapter 128-4

The air fell silent for a few seconds. Wang Zhaozhao and Xiao Bai looked toward Liang Shi in unison.

After the initial awkwardness, Liang Shi also bravely admitted it.

She nodded. "Mm, I'm not."

Not only was she not straight, she was bent like a mosquito coil.¹

Xiao Bai quickly said, "Sister Liang, I didn't mean it that way. It's... being gay is fine too. Sexual orientation is free now, okay? It's those trash people online who always use sexual orientation to attack others. They're shameless."

"Besides, what's wrong with liking girls? If Sister Liang liked me, I could bend immediately." Xiao Bai explained in a fluster so as not to make Liang Shi feel uncomfortable. "Getting close and cuddly with a beautiful older sister, I can do it."

Wang Zhaozhao watched with a complicated expression, practically having "Is this what you fucking call being straight?" written on her face.

Liang Shi pushed her away, ignoring her starry eyes. "I..."

Before she could finish speaking, Xiao Bai immediately said, "Oh right, except for that dog Cheng Cheng. A straight girl pretending to be gay deserves to be struck by lightning. And to turn around and bite back? That deserves five thunderbolts.² Sister Liang, your taste has always been good. No matter who you like, you can't like that kind of awful thing."

Liang Shi: "..."

She pushed away Xiao Bai, who kept moving closer, and cleared her throat. "I already have someone I like."

Xiao Bai: "?"

Wang Zhaozhao: "?"

The two asked in unison: "Who?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, wearing thick gloves as she lifted the pot lid. The rich aroma of fish soup immediately spread throughout the kitchen.

Steam surrounded Liang Shi, making her look especially ethereal.

A strand of hair fell by her ear. She used her free hand to tuck it behind her ear—a particularly beautiful scene.

Xiao Bai gulped and said righteously, "It's not Sun Chengcheng, is it?"

Wang Zhaozhao immediately dismissed the idea. "She's neither crazy nor blind. How could she like that thing?"

Liang Shi was amused by the two of them but quickly composed herself.

After a moment, she rubbed her earlobe and said, "Her name is—Xu Qingzhu."

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When this name came out of Liang Shi's mouth again, it felt like a lifetime had passed.

And she said with certainty—I like this person.

Introducing this person to Sister Wang and Xiao Bai felt especially like bringing a girlfriend home to meet the parents, even though the girlfriend wasn't here at the moment.

And the "parents" had no idea who she was.

She couldn't pinpoint which moment her heart had been moved.

But in the days without Xu Qingzhu, she always felt listless.

Before, this kind of ordinary life with its everyday joys could give her immense satisfaction. But now she was living the life she wanted, yet felt empty because Xu Qingzhu wasn't in it.

That person had seeped into her life like water, filling her completely.

As a result, now that this person wasn't in her life, her life was a mess.

Liang Shi was already trying hard to live, but she couldn't accept a life without Xu Qingzhu.

She had never learned about such things and didn't know what liking was, or what love was.

But she thought, this must be it, right?

Missing someone to the point of tears, wanting to go back and stay by her side.

Even in days so boring she would zone out, as long as that person was in the same space as her, those would be brilliantly radiant days.

Liang Shi brought the fish soup to the table. Under the urging gazes of Sister Wang and Xiao Bai, she slowly recounted what had happened during those days.

She didn't mention those strange settings.

She said she had gone on a journey and met many people.

There was Xu Qingzhu, Zhao Xuning, Shen Hui, Zhou Yi'an, Gu Xingyue, Qi Jiao, and many, many more.

She said she had gained family members who doted on her, and someone who would watch movies with her.

They had spent many unforgettable nights together.

Liang Shi said, "Only by her side do I feel truly alive."

The days before meeting her had been flavorful enough.

But after meeting her, it was magnificent waves, rolling peaks and valleys, gentle tides.

Because the days spent with her were so, so beautiful, it made the current days seem even more boring.

"Having crossed the vast ocean, no other waters can compare; having seen the clouds of Mount Wu, no other clouds can measure up."²

Xiao Bai used this poem to summarize and elevate the moment.

As a result, Wang Zhaozhao shot her a look. "Only you would understand?"

Xiao Bai sheepishly touched the tip of her nose. "I was just moved listening to it."

Wang Zhaozhao ignored her.

After finishing her story, Liang Shi said, "Actually, I wasn't moved at first. It was later that I realized she had already become a part of my life. I kept thinking of her unconsciously. Seeing her smile would make me happy; seeing her cry would make me sad. This... is liking someone, right?"

She asked cautiously.

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1. Bent like a mosquito coil (彎成了蚊香): A humorous Chinese internet slang. "Bent" (彎) is slang for being gay/homosexual (as opposed to "straight"). A mosquito coil is a spiral-shaped incense used to repel mosquitoes, so being "bent like a mosquito coil" means being extremely gay—not just a little bent, but coiled around multiple times. ⇐
 2. Five thunderbolts (五雷轟頂): A traditional Chinese curse meaning to be struck by five types of thunder/lightning. It's an intensified version of "struck by lightning" (天打雷劈), expressing that someone deserves severe divine punishment for their wrongdoing. ⇐
 3. "Having crossed the vast ocean..." (曾經滄海難為水，除卻巫山不是雲): A famous line from a poem by Yuan Zhen (779-831), a Tang Dynasty poet. It means that after experiencing something truly extraordinary (like the vast ocean or the mystical clouds of Mount Wu), nothing else can compare. It's commonly used to describe a love so profound that no one else could ever measure up. The full implication is that once you've loved someone deeply, no one else will ever be enough. ⇐

Chapter 128-5

Xiao Bai had already grabbed tissues from beside the table to wipe her tears, sobbing as she said, "How is this just liking someone?"

Liang Shi was startled. "Huh?"

Xiao Bai: "This is love, wuwuwuwu."

Wang Zhaozhao was speechless. She smacked the back of Xiao Bai's head. "Shut up."

Xiao Bai: "..."

Wang Zhaozhao looked toward Liang Shi, about to say something but was interrupted by Liang Shi: "Jiě, I know you think I'm dreaming, that it's wishful thinking, that it's all my imagination. But I think feelings can't lie. The reason I'm telling you all this isn't to seek your approval, or to make you understand what strange things I've experienced. I'm simply telling you... I have someone I like."

Wang Zhaozhao's expression gradually became solemn.

Liang Shi smiled. "This is something worth being happy about, right?"

"Of course." As a young person, Xiao Bai was quick to accept new things. She raised the fish soup in front of her. "Sister Liang, a toast to you and your girlfriend's love. Even if this is an imaginary girlfriend, I still give my blessings."

Liang Shi: "..."

But Wang Zhaozhao asked seriously, "How long have you had these symptoms?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Her headache got worse.

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Liang Shi didn't say more to Wang Zhaozhao and the others, nor did she insist they believe another world existed.

She said very seriously, "Whether you believe it or not, I have to believe it anyway."

Wang Zhaozhao asked, "Why?"

Liang Shi smiled slightly. "If I forgot her, she would be very sad."

Liang Shi's smile was gentle, leaving even Xiao Bai dazed.

Xiao Bai called it a Bodhisattva descending to earth. She said that in that moment, Liang Shi was radiating holy light.

Wang Zhaozhao called her an idiot.

Seeing Liang Shi like this, Wang Zhaozhao didn't say anything more and ate quietly.

Meanwhile, Xiao Bai kept gossiping throughout the meal, asking Liang Shi how tall her girlfriend was, how slim, how beautiful, and what she did for a living.

Liang Shi answered each question. The person she described was very vivid and detailed.

When leaving, Wang Zhaozhao said quietly to Liang Shi, "If you have time, come back to the hospital with me for another checkup."

Liang Shi smiled helplessly. "Sister Wang, I'm really fine."

"Then..." Wang Zhaozhao paused, her voice low and heavy, "Do you really want to go back?"

Liang Shi was stunned, then nodded after a moment.

"You want to find Sun Chengcheng for this reason too?" Wang Zhaozhao asked.

Liang Shi nodded again.

Sun Chengcheng hadn't been erased from this world, yet she could still appear in another world.

Moreover, Wang Zhaozhao said she had seen Sun Chengcheng at some event a few days ago, though she was doing terribly. This confirmed that Sun Chengcheng was still alive in this world too.

So she might be freely traveling between the two worlds.

Liang Shi wasn't surprised by this. That crappy system had created too many bugs. Having Sun Chengcheng as one of them wasn't surprising at all.

It was just that Sun Chengcheng had moved. Most people in the entertainment industry couldn't contact her. Her agency had also terminated her contract, and she had changed her phone number. No one knew where she lived now.

Wang Zhaozhao didn't want Liang Shi to get caught up in such troublesome matters, so when Liang Shi had mentioned it before, she hadn't taken it to heart.

This time she said, "I'll try. I'll get back to you as soon as possible."

She didn't ask what would happen if Liang Shi went back, or whether Liang Shi could choose not to leave.

She simply stood behind Liang Shi as always, clearly expressing her attitude—since you want to do this, I'll help you.

Liang Shi smiled. "Thank you, Jiě."

After they left, before they had walked far, Xiao Bai asked Wang Zhaozhao, "Jiějie, do you think Sister Liang damaged her brain from the fall? Why does what she's saying sound so sci-fi?"

Wang Zhaozhao shot her a look. "Weren't you being very believing just now?"

"Sister Liang was speaking so sincerely and emotionally, she was about to cry. If I refuted her, wouldn't she be very sad?" Xiao Bai said. "But do you think parallel worlds really exist?"

"There are all kinds of wonders in this vast world."¹ Wang Zhaozhao stood there pressing the elevator button, standing shoulder to shoulder with Bai Qi.

Bai Qi suddenly said, "Then doesn't that mean Sister Liang's girlfriend is now like us before, watching over someone in a coma?"

Wang Zhaozhao: "..."

"I feel sorry for her." Bai Qi said.

Wang Zhaozhao: "..."

"She's not your partner. Why are you feeling sorry for her?" Wang Zhaozhao was exasperated.

Bai Qi sighed. "I feel sorry for Sister Liang!"

They entered the elevator. Liang Shi, who had been standing by the door eavesdropping on everything, shook her head helplessly and revealed a bitter smile.

That night, she wrote in her diary: [Xu Qingzhu, it's raining here. What about you?]

[Xu Qingzhu, I miss you. Do you miss me?]

[Are you crying again? Don't cry. I'll come find you.]

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1. There are all kinds of wonders in this vast world (大千世界無奇不有): A Chinese saying meaning that in this vast world, nothing is too strange to exist. It expresses the idea that anything is possible and one shouldn't be surprised by unusual occurrences. ↩

Chapter 128-6

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"I didn't cry." Xu Qingzhu brushed away Sally's hand. "Can you stop being annoying?"

Sally scoffed lightly. "Then what's with your eye bags? Please, Liang Shi is in a coma, not dead... ah..."

Lin Luoxi stepped on Sally's foot. Facing Sally's puzzled gaze, Lin Luoxi revealed a death smile. "If you don't know how to speak, you can shut up."

Sally: "..."

Xu Qingzhu, who was nearby, chimed in: "I agree."

It had been half a month since Liang Shi fell into a coma. The weather in Haizhou City was getting colder and colder. People on the streets had already put on down jackets.

Although snow hadn't fallen yet, the temperature had plummeted.

Xu Qingzhu, Lin Luoxi, and Sally took advantage of their lunch break to sneak out and eat hot pot lamb.¹

The warm restaurant was filled with rising steam everywhere. Sally's words were unpleasant to hear, and she was called out by the other two. She then tried her best to express her accurate thoughts in Chinese: "What I mean is, Liang Shi will be fine."

Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes. "I really don't know how you've survived these years in China. Your Chinese is this bad."

Sally: "Hm?"

She didn't understand again.

Lin Luoxi was speechless. Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Isn't it because you spoiled her? Ever since you two started dating, you've always been speaking English to accommodate her."

Lin Luoxi: "..."

After a moment, Lin Luoxi had no choice but to admit: "You're right."

She gritted her teeth resentfully. "I don't even know what I saw in her back then. I must have been blind."

Sally understood this. She immediately retorted: "Baby, I'm pretty."

Lin Luoxi: "...Get lost. Stop disgusting me."

The two began another round of bickering.

Xu Qingzhu sat across from them holding her cup with both hands, treating it like watching a crosstalk performance.²

There was a smile on her face, but it seemed fake.

These days she had returned to normal, going to work as usual every day. After work, she would go to the hospital to see Liang Shi. Even though both Xu Guangyao and Su Zhe had advised her that she could return to the company later, she still completed her discharge procedures after staying in the hospital for three days and went to the company almost without stopping.

Chen Liuying's actions could be classified as intentional injury and attempted murder, with aggravated kidnapping circumstances. On the day she was arrested, public officials were also injured, which was all counted against her.

Su Zhe intended to push for a life sentence. Getting a death penalty here was somewhat difficult. Unless it was someone like Yang Jiani, that perverted serial killer, the maximum sentence would be life imprisonment.

Su Zhe wasn't without connections either. Once Chen Liuying was locked up, making her suffer a bit would be the most normal thing.

As for Yang Jiani's case, it was also going through the process. Gu Xingyue had been staying in the hospital ever since she was admitted. After learning that Liang Shi had fallen into a coma, she couldn't sleep all night and finally couldn't help but go to see her.

She saw Xu Qingzhu outside the hospital room.

That was also the first time Xu Qingzhu met Gu Xingyue. The two didn't speak, only nodded simply.

Then they passed each other by.

Both Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe learned about Liang Shi's coma and came to visit several times during this period. Liang Xinzhou even brought in foreign specialists for Liang Shi, but after thorough examinations, there were no findings.

A coma of unknown cause was the most terrifying.

For the moment, they were at a loss. Her heart rate was normal; it was just that her cerebral cortex wasn't active. All they could do was wait.

Zhou Li brought Rainbow to visit too. Rainbow and Ling Dang sat side by side in front of Liang Shi's hospital bed.

Ling Dang asked Rainbow: "When do you think my aunt will wake up?"

Rainbow shook her head. "I don't know."

The two children sat there. Ling Dang said: "I want to become a doctor in the future, so I can save my aunt."

Rainbow said nothing.

A few seconds later, Ling Dang changed her mind: "Forget it, you should become a doctor instead. You're smarter."

Rainbow: "?"

"Is that not okay?" Ling Dang said. "Will you become a doctor?"

Rainbow was silent for a long time, then said firmly: "Yes."

"Then you have to become a really, really amazing doctor, so you can wake up my aunt." Ling Dang said.

Rainbow nodded.

Liang Shi's hospital room also had a constant stream of visitors, but everyone tacitly understood that the time after Xu Qingzhu got off work belonged exclusively to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu would often sit in a daze by her hospital bed, her thoughts scattered.

At night, she would occasionally sleep in the hospital room, but most of the time she would go home.

After all, home and the hospital weren't far apart.

Xu Qingzhu's life consisted of three points in a line: home, company, hospital.

She actually didn't really want to go back to that home. It was cold and empty when she returned.

As for how her eyes got swollen, she didn't know either.

She definitely didn't cry before going to sleep.

She seemed to often cry in her dreams. Every morning when she woke up, her eyes looked like they had been washed with water.

She had gotten used to this kind of life.

"Used to"—what a terrifying phrase.

She would occasionally tell Liang Shi stories by her ear, hoping she would wake up after hearing them.

But she never did.

Even Zhou Yi'an came to see Liang Shi once. She even asked Xu Qingzhu: "Will she come back?"

Xu Qingzhu was startled, not understanding why Zhou Yi'an would ask such a question.

But Xu Qingzhu just shook her head sincerely: "I don't know either."

Who would know about such uncertain things?

Meanwhile, on the other side of the city, Sun Chengcheng completed her task and unlocked the second capture target character card.

She chose without hesitation—the investor with a discerning eye.

Soon, the character card's information appeared before her.

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1. Hot pot lamb (涮羊肉, shuàn yáng ròu): A Chinese hot pot dish where thin slices of lamb are quickly cooked by dipping them in boiling broth. It's a popular winter dish, especially in northern China. ↵
 2. Crosstalk (相声, xiàngshēng): A traditional Chinese comedic performance art, typically performed by a duo who engage in witty banter, wordplay, and comedic dialogue. Xu Qingzhu is comparing Lin Luoxi and Sally's bickering to watching a comedy routine. ↵

Chapter 128-7

Character A: Xu Qingzhu. She is the heir to Minghui Jewelry and also the heir to Haiwei Jewelry. She comes from a prestigious family and has exceptional looks. In the future, she will earn a fortune through her discerning investment vision, establish a new conglomerate, and secure a place in Haizhou City's business empire.

"Top student" is her synonym, and "logic freak" is another nickname of hers.

She could clearly make a living off her looks, yet she insists on relying on her talent.

The person she likes most is the older sister who was kidnapped with her when she was young, but... no, it's Character B, Lu Jiayi.

She hates having her eyes covered, hates having her hands and feet bound, hates all things dark.

She is cold in demeanor but kind-hearted, and extremely protective of her own. As long as someone is included in her circle of "her people," they can receive her preferential treatment.

In the future, she will heavily invest in the entertainment industry and become an investor mogul whose word is law in the entertainment world. Host, please seize the opportunity.

Character B: Lu Jiayi. The first heir of the Lu family in the Capital,¹ fluent in seven languages, 170cm tall, single.

Outwardly gentle in personality, making people feel like a spring breeze when interacting with her—in reality, she's just dumbing herself down to match others.²

She is an ambitious businesswoman. At home, she has two younger brothers and two younger sisters eyeing her position, plus her father's two illegitimate children outside who are watching her position like tigers stalking prey. She must remain vigilant at all times to keep herself in an unassailable position.

To her, love is something dispensable. Only power is real.

She is an extremely discerning investor. The greatest investment of her life was... investing in Xu Qingzhu.

.....

Similar to Gu Yixue's character card from last time, it was a full page of extensive information.

The system giving her these two character cards indicated that both people were similarly important. Building a good relationship with either one would work.

But she was currently in Haizhou City, so naturally Xu Qingzhu was her first choice.

Sun Chengcheng's plan was also very clear. She already had the "Affection Value UP" buff on her. Anyone who saw her would develop favorable feelings toward her.

Through her tireless efforts, she had already raised it to 20, which was considered a very high peak value.

For the current Xu Qingzhu, she just needed to do what Lu Jiayi did—invest in Xu Qingzhu.

Sun Chengcheng was in the middle of planning when she suddenly heard an ethereal knocking sound. She was puzzled, and while she was thinking, she was yanked out by a forceful power. Only after experiencing tremendous pain did she open her eyes.

Then she discovered this was her room.

She was back in the real world again.

How annoying.

If she could, she wished she could just stay in that world and never wake up. According to the 1:3 time flow ratio between the real world and the game world, she would live much longer than others.

There, civilization and art were highly developed, and she existed like someone with cheat codes.

However... why was she woken up by the knocking sound from this world this time?

This had never happened before.

Before she could think about it carefully, the knocking outside the door grew louder and louder. Sun Chengcheng irritably ran her hand through her hair, put on slippers, and got up to open the door.

As she pulled open the door, she said impatiently, "Stop knocking..."

Her words came to an abrupt halt when she saw the person at the door. She instinctively tried to close the door, but Liang Shi, quick of eye and hand, pressed against it and forcefully pushed open her door. Sun Chengcheng visibly panicked. "Liang... Liang Shi... Aren't you dead?"

"You're the one who's dead!" Xiao Bai immediately spoke up. "Damn it, seeing you is just bad luck!"

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1. The Capital (京都, Jīngdū): Here referring to Beijing, the capital city of China. In Chinese, 京都 literally means "capital city" and is often used to refer to Beijing in literary or formal contexts. ↩
 2. Dumbing herself down to match others (向下兼容): Literally "backward compatibility," a term borrowed from technology/computing. In this context, it means Lu Jiayi is intellectually superior but deliberately lowers herself to match others' levels when interacting with them, making them feel comfortable while she's actually operating far above them. ↩